

of divulging the details of a Lulzsec member to the authorities.

Here are some of the more reputable VPNs that we know of:

- <http://btguard.com/>
- <https://www.privateinternetaccess.com/>
- <http://torguard.net/>
- <https://airvpn.org/>

VPNs are only good if they're up and running. As a user who is worried about security, it's important that you ensure that you're actually connected to the VPN at all times. Of course, you can't keep track of the connections at every moment of the day, so you can use utilities such as *VPNNetMon* and *VPNCheck* to keep track of your connection and ensure that you're connected at all times.

One more thing you need to monitor is the DNS server you're connected to. For a VPN to work, you must be using their DNS servers as well and websites such as <https://www.dnsleaktest.com/> will let you verify the DNS networks that you're connected to and have access to.

Browser plug-ins

VPNs and proxy-servers are good, but there are some simple browser plug-ins that can make your life a whole lot more private. Here are some of the more useful ones.

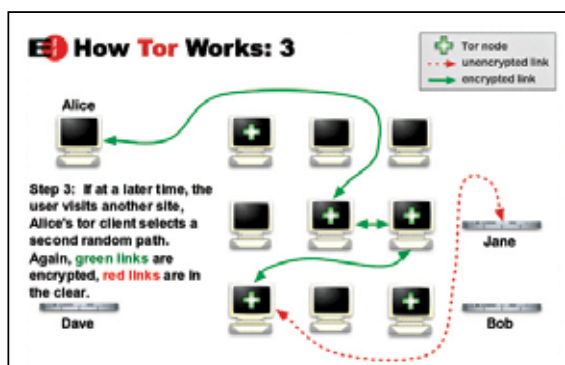
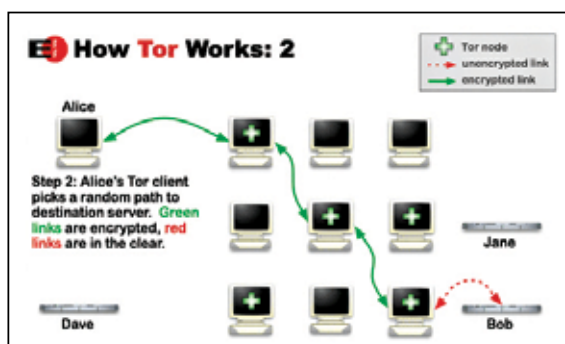
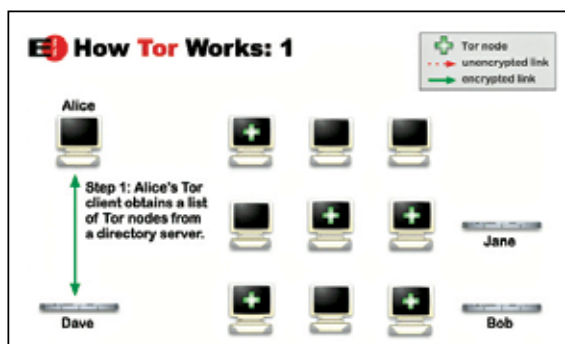
- **HTTPSEverywhere:** This plug-in forces websites to use the HTTPS protocol where possible. Of course, government agencies and other such agencies will probably still track you down, but for the average joe, this is enough. (<https://www.eff.org/httpseverywhere>)
- **DoNotTrackMe:** An interesting plug-in, this plug-in enables the DoNotTrack feature wherever possible. It does its level best to protect your information from the Internet. (<https://www.abine.com/dntdetail.php>)
- **Ad-Block Plus:** Almost everyone who is even vaguely geeky has used this plug-in. Now this isn't a true privacy plug-in per se; it blocks out almost all ads and in effect, might save you from the hassle of accidentally clicking on an ad and leaving a tracking cookie on your system. (<https://adblockplus.org/>)

TOR

This network will probably require an entire article on its own. The TOR network is seen as the bastion for privacy seekers and while it does draw a fair share of flak for being an enabler for the truly dark and demented side of the Internet (child pornography, drug-dealing and other such nefarious activities), it does have a reputation for being the most secure and anonymous network the world has yet seen. This is supposedly one of the very few networks that the NSA hasn't cracked yet.

TOR works by randomizing the route your Internet traffic takes by running it through the TOR network and erasing all traces (logs) along the way, effectively giving you anonymous access to anything.

TOR can be downloaded from <http://dgit.in/TTORR>. Just be sure to follow all the instructions on that page.



Secure file-sharing and messaging

Sharing files online can be an issue if you're really worried about privacy. While services such as drop-box and Skydrive are very good, they store the information online, meaning that there is a possibility that the data can be hacked into. The same goes for all your messaging and chat needs.

Two services can come to your aid here, both provided by the BitTorrent network.

- **BTSync:** This service uses the BitTorrent protocol (P2P) to sync files between PCs or servers. The system doesn't use any third-party servers to store or mediate the data transfer, making the connection as secure as possible.
- **BTChat:** This service is very similar to BTSync, the only difference being that the protocol is used for chatting and messaging rather than file transfer. The service is still in the testing phase though and you can apply for access to the alpha at <http://dgit.in/16STiBt>.

Use your head

Using these basic tools and following the steps that we've listed out you'll, be a ghost online. Just remember that these are only tools and are only as good as the person who makes use of them. Even the world's greatest hackers have been unmasked and they've been unmasked by old-fashioned police work rather than by some super-geeky sleuth who's voice is yet to break. Regardless of how you're trying to remain anonymous, there's a more than even chance that you can be found if someone really wants to find you. Always work under the assumption that you can and will be tracked and conduct yourself accordingly. Don't do anything that you'll regret.

More importantly, don't use these tools to engage in illegal activities and expect to be safe. Even the most secure VPNs have been known to cooperate with authorities when it comes to taking down real criminals. **[E]**